

Ergonomics

Sure a notebook is the sum of all its components but it's much more than that as well. For us, a notebook is as personal as a PMP or cellphone and special attention needs to be paid to the usability and ergonomics of the notebook rather than just its components. In fact the more you use a notebook the more discerning you become towards any ergonomic shortcomings. For example, the inclusion of dedicated switches/buttons to switch on/off WLAN and Bluetooth and dedicated multimedia keys is a real plus point.

A dedicated switch to turn off the track-pad is another plus; since while typing you don't really need to use it and accidental brushes with your wrist can have undesired results. The layout of the keys on the keyboard is also worth mention; obviously this is highly subjective to what your personal tastes are and what you are used to.



Segregated keypads

This design concept is used mainly by Sony and Apple. Such keypads have smaller keys and the bevilling is usually minimal. This is because the adjacent keys have a small gap between each other so false key presses are minimised. Some people find such keypads much easier to work with; others do not. But you have to try which type suits you best and while you will get used to even a bad keypad; you will immediately notice the difference between one that suits your fingers and one that doesn't



Bevilled keypads

Such keypads are used by all other major vendors including Dell, HP, Lenovo, Fujitsu and Toshiba among others. The keys are bevilled and the keys are very close to each other. The bevilling and small depression atop the each key is what allows ou to avoid false key presses. Opinions on comfort and usability differ

Laptops



Multimedia keys

Having buttons for playback, next and previous tracks, stop, pause and volume mute is just so convenient. Even non-multimedia notebooks should have them



Switches and buttons

Buttons are switches should be present for the most common functions like launching your browser, opening the media player or even switching WLAN on and off. Convenience is the name of the game here



Dedicated keys

Some notebooks will have dedicated for some fixed applications and these are usually configurable using software